natural place for us to call home.'

Once Brooklyn arrived and we knew we were getting married, I think instinct kicked in. We knew we wanted somewhere to bring up a family, somewhere we could always call home. We had a pretty good idea where we wanted the Beckhams to be based: north and east of London, near our parents, and not too far from the highways. We knew we wanted space for Brooklyn to run around, safely and in privacy. We knew we wanted room to have friends and family over without having to squeeze anyone in. We wanted to be able to throw a decent party. Me? I had to make sure I had enough space for a snooker table and a long enough wall for my collection of signed shirts. It was time to stretch out a little after a year and a half of living out of suitcases, stopping at Tony and Jackie's or at the apartment in Cheshire.

The place we found was in Hertfordshire, on the edge of a little village called Sawbridgeworth. The first place we looked at belonged to the boxing promoter Frank warren. I liked it but Victoria wasn't sure: perhaps it would have been too big for us. The house in Sawbridgeworth hardly needed a second look: Victoria fell in love with it straight away. The buildings and the grounds were the right sort of scale. I know people call it Beckingham Palace but it's a family home when all's said and done. It's manageable without needing an army of helpers. There was plenty of work to be done to it, and maybe that was what got Victoria so excited about it. I'm like her in that I've got very particular tastes in things: you could say we've got a liking for 'subtle over-the-top', the pair of us. What Victoria had, though, was the imagination to see how she could turn the place into somewhere we'd love. She also had a dad who had the knowledge and found the time to organize the details. Tony was the unpaid project manager for Sawbridgeworth when he wasn't running his own building business. I bet he had no idea what he'd be taking on when we said: please, we need someone we trust. It took the best part of four years to make all the changes that Victoria had imagined the moment we first drove through the gates.

Sawbridgeworth was about putting down roots. Until I pack in the game, though, I'm the same as any other player. It's something you take on as part of being a professional: your life revolves around training and games. It has to. Even one of the biggest days of my life, my wedding day, had to get squeezed into its place in the middle of the United calendar. At least there wasn't a World Cup or a European Championship to rush off to over the summer of 1999. Once I'd come down from the incredible high of the European Cup that May, and once I'd been convinced I should take off the winners' medal I had slung round my neck for days afterwards, we were able to concentrate on the